

2026 Quarterly Tax Cheat Sheet

For 1099 Freelancers, Independent Contractors & Self-Employed Professionals

2026
TAX YEAR

ESTIMATED TAX DUE DATES

Q1 Apr 15, 2026 Jan 1 – Mar 31	Q2 Jun 15, 2026 Apr 1 – May 31	Q3 Sep 15, 2026 Jun 1 – Aug 31	Q4 Jan 15, 2027 Sep 1 – Dec 31
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SE TAX CALCULATION

STEP-BY-STEP FORMULA

- 1 Net profit from Schedule C
- 2 × 92.35% = SE net earnings
- 3 × 15.3% = SE tax owed
- 4 Deduct 50% of SE tax from gross income
- 5 Add to income tax for total quarterly payment

Most freelancers underestimate by skipping step 4

2026 KEY RATES & THRESHOLDS

SE tax rate	15.3%
SE tax base factor	92.35%
SS wage base ceiling	\$184,500
Medicare rate above ceiling	2.9%
Standard deduction — single	\$16,100
Standard deduction — MFJ	\$32,200
QBI deduction (pass-through)	20% of QBI

SAFE HARBOR — AVOID UNDERPAYMENT PENALTY

- RULE 1** Pay **100% of prior year tax** in four equal installments. No penalty regardless of actual 2026 liability.
- RULE 2** If 2025 AGI exceeded **\$150,000**, pay **110% of prior year tax** instead.
- RULE 3** Alternatively, pay **90% of actual 2026 tax** by January 15, 2027. Higher risk if income is unpredictable.

Practical approach: Divide last year's total tax by 4. Pay that amount by each due date. You are protected from underpayment penalties even if your income increases significantly in 2026.

KEY SELF-EMPLOYMENT DEDUCTIONS

50% of SE tax paid	Calculated
Health insurance premiums (self-paid)	100%
SEP-IRA / Solo 401(k) contributions	Up to 25% net
Home office (exclusive use)	Actual or \$5/sq ft
Business use of vehicle	67¢/mile (2024 rate — verify 2026)
Software, tools, subscriptions	100% if business-use
Professional development	100% if field-related
QBI deduction (pass-through income)	Up to 20% of QBI